



RAVI S. SAHANI

GROWING ANGER: Protesters in Jammu; Advani at the Aradhana Divas held in Delhi (below)



SIPRA DAS

“This denial of land is an affront to the Hindu sentiments and another example of flawed secularism.”

L.K. ADVANI, SENIOR BJP LEADER

in both regions. Not only has it cut short a dream tourist season in Kashmir, the flow of pilgrims to Vaishno Devi and the Amarnath shrine has reduced to a trickle. Vohra's Valley-centric slipshod damage-control didn't earn him friends in Kashmir, but it has certainly made him a hate figure in Jammu. The samiti is now baying for his blood, making his recall one of the prerequisites—a demand the Centre has rejected.

While the sharply conflicting views of the state political parties on the solution of the Amarnath land row depends on which side of the Pir Panjal range they belong to, what they agree on is that election is the last thing the state can have in the next two months. “In such a surcharged atmosphere, the Valley politicians dare not campaign in Jammu and vice versa,” said senior Kashmiri CPI(M) leader Mohammad Yousuf Tarigami. “The turmoil may bring the state back to square one of the '90s and could fritter away all the gains that the elected political dispensations have made in the last decade,” he feared.

Only separatists have gained from this flare-up. Mirwaiz Farooq, chairman of the moderate Hurriyat faction, even suggested that the Kashmiris have no objections to carving out of a Hindu-dominated Dogra Dosh out of the Jammu province—harking back to the dubious Dixon Plan that had suggested a Muslim-majority state south of the Chenab. “It's an explosive situation where a solution can lead to a bigger mess,” said a top state bureaucrat and member of the governor's crisis-management team. For, what is at play in India's most volatile region is a sense of historical hurt. For a generation that grew out of the Hindu exodus from the Valley, the divide marks the beginning of another Partition within. What is at stake is the emotional as well as cultural integrity of India. ■